

ANI

MULTIPLE SORTIES
Modi after a sortie on Tejas fighter aircraft, Nov. 25; (far-left) visiting an ISRO facility in Bengaluru after the Chandrayaan-3 landing, Aug. 26

by betting on fresh faces for chief ministers, including on a first-time MLA, Bhajan Lal Sharma. BJP president J.P. Nadda says, "Modiji always leads from the front, asks for the minutest details, is sharply focused and every sentence he speaks brings out an important observation. He always wants a wider choice, and more youngsters to be brought into leadership roles. In every election, he urges us to go aggressively forward, tackle issues that strengthen the party and test our strength. When the BJP wins, all he says is 'Good work, but now look ahead'."

Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma says the PM never discusses politics of the state with him but is keen on knowing how he is ensuring inclusive economic growth. One thing Sarma has learned is to take notes whenever the PM meets him, for he knows that in the next meeting, Modi would reel out all the points they had discussed and enquire about the progress made. Modi even advised Sarma to tell his ministers to form MLA clusters, invite a group for lunch every month so as to listen to their feedback on how the government is performing. He then told Sarma that whenever he opened a new party office, he should invite the elder partymen in that block and wash their feet (in an aside, he also wanted to know what Sarma felt when he did this). Says Sarma, "Modi*ji* gives us full freedom to run the government the way we want to. I feel that with every interaction I become richer as a human being and more mature as a politician."

THE CEO

Modi's other avatar is that of a CEO. Rajeev Chandrasekhar, Union minister of state for electronics and information technology, would vouch for this. He recalls a recent policy presentation of his ministry (which he thought was brilliant) till Modi pointed out that there were no details of how he was going to harmonise it with other ministries. The minister confessed that he hadn't thought of it and Modi asked him to include that before he cleared it. Chandrasekhar says, "Modi*ji* could be 80,000 feet above sea level, but he backs every vision with his feet on the ground. There is a robustness with which he approaches every issue, an underpinning of substantive knowledge and experience that helps execute solutions."

In the interview, Modi explained how he arrived at the decisions he takes. He says, "I believe in learning from the experiences and wisdom of others. So, in a way, I am blessed with a strong ground connect. My approach to policymaking is to listen to all the economists and experts and formulate my policies and strategies through a mix of their advice, my 'ground connect' and the 'lived reality' of the country. As a result of my ground connection, I have strong convictions. *Mein kuchh bhi achha lage isliye nahi karta, achha ho isliye karta hoon* (I don't do things because it looks good, I do it because it will do good)." He believes in the optimal usage of resources and outcome-oriented monitoring.

The prime minister is a great one for constantly brainstorming with experts to keep up to date with major developments, and expects the same from his team too. When OpenAI CEO Sam Altman called on him in June 2023 to discuss the early adoption of ChatGPT, Modi called an impromptu meeting with NITI Aayog CEO B.V.R. Subrahmanyam and his team and got them to listen in to what the man had to say about the future of AI. Modi also enjoys playing with technology himself. Dr Hiren Joshi, OSD (communications & information technology) in the PMO, says that when he recently sent the prime minister an AI software that helped compose music, Modi immediately created some music on it. Later, he sent a note to Joshi saying he didn't find the software good enough.

THE TECH CHAMPION

That's another avatar of Modi, the Tech Champion. The prime minister is clear that India should leapfrog into what he calls "the Techade"; in 2023, the government launched missions on mastering quantum computing, semiconductor chip manufacturing and AI, sewing up collaborations with major countries, including the US. Modi points out, "The semiconductor mission is something we should have started 30 years ago. We